Statement for the Record
Re: CUP230002

To:
Riverside County Planning Department
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From:
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Attn: Krista Mason, Project Planner

Riverside County Ordinance 348, the Riverside County General Plan and other key Riverside County documents maintain a recurrent theme supporting the health, safety and wellbeing of community members. Collectively, health, safety and welfare include but is not limited to physical, emotional, and socio-economic factors. Of the numerous questions and concerns about the proposed Crescent Garden Cemetery, this statement for the record addresses only two (2) prominent issues of proximity that have a profound physical, emotional, and socio-economic impact, in an effort to be brief.

For the record this statement primarily concerns that residential property at APN 349 180 026 that is partially surrounded by 4 of the 21 proposed cemetery parcels such that these 4 parcels wraps around the entire southern and eastern borders of parcel number 349 180 026. The four cemetery parcels are APN 349-180-006, APN 349-180-007, APN 349-180-008 and APN 349-180-035.

First Prominent Proximity Issue:
The proposed graves on the east border of parcel 349 180 026 will be in full view from residence's kitchen windows and family room windows, because of the minimal proposed setback from the property line. If the view of burial sites was from a small obscure window such as a bathroom that is rarely used, this issue would be less concerning.

The adverse impact is further exacerbated by the idea of seeing graves being dug and funeral processions or gravesite ceremonies taking place while eating at the table next to the kitchen on the adjoining covered balcony that overlooks the proposed gravesites.

Since **graves generally lay uncovered for up to a year or more** while they wait for a row of graves to be occupied and settled, it would subject the residents of parcel 349 180 026 to not only the view of grave digging and funeral activities, but also the continuous view of uncovered and unsettled graves. When one row is finally settled and covered, and the proposed concrete band is laid around that row, the process would begin again for the next

row, then again for the next row, and so on, for an ongoing view of uncovered graves year after year after year…while eating.

Humans generally avoid thinking about death. The forced day to day reminder of death, while, cooking, eating and sharing family time…day after day and year after year, borders on the realm cruelty and jeopardizes the emotional health and psychological wellbeing of the residents at parcel number 349 180 026.

The residents' wellbeing is not the only issue. Of mutual concern is the heartfelt desire to be **respectful to grieving families** who may be subjected to the merry-making sights and sounds of festive music and celebrations that take place up on that balcony...while mourners are grieving the loss of a loved one at grave side.

Do note that eye level at the kitchen and balcony is 14 feet above ground, because the living spaces of this residence are on the upper floor. The lay of the area's hilly landscape is such that even a 7 ft. fence and trees would not adequately minimize the impact of the grave sites so close to the property line, below the balcony, kitchen and family room windows at the eastern border of APN 349-180-026.

Also note that the space up at the kitchen balcony accommodates a larger than family sized gathering and that celebrations spill over to the yard at that eastern border such that even a 7 ft. fence and trees would not mitigate celebration sights and sounds despite the desire to be respectful to those grieving the loss of their loves ones at the proposed property line grave sites at the east border of APN 349-180-026.

Second Prominent Proximity Issue:

The second prominent issue, is an overwhelming concern about the distance between naturally decaying bodies at the burial sites and the domestic water well at APN 349-180-026, particularly in light of the challenge in estimating the number and frequency of funerals and the hundreds (estimated over 800) of volatile organic compounds from a single decomposing body. If just some of these leach into the soil, and into unseen underground water veins that feed into the well, it would be difficult to calculate the repercussions ....of note is the unpredictable and dramatic increase in death rates during a pandemic along with the associated biological waste and the illnesses that are yet to be discovered and classified by the World Health Organization.

The assurances in reports of water quality studies and proposed safety measures provide little comfort when compared to living here and experiencing the enormity of flooding when it rains. I can share saved images of flooding (both still and video), but they only partially convey the overwhelming deluge that nature sends. I can also testify about our vehicles sliding down hill as we gingerly make our way down the driveway in the rain, or about the countless vehicles our neighborhood residents have helped to get unstuck when those who are not familiar with the terrain slide off the unfamiliar rain soaked dirt roads and are spinning their tires in vein as they sink further into the mud. Even without seeing it first hand, we can all agree that mud slides happen and water flows downhill…in this case, down to the registered floodplain limits area at the bottom of the hill, near the bottom of our driveway entrance.

Though I believe contamination of the surface water flow would adversely impact everyone in this area, I can only speculate about exactly how contamination of this surface flow affects the public utility water supply. It is logical to conclude that the public water utility company would need to invest in newer and more methods to address new and more contaminants. And logic would dictate higher and higher costs for customers.

It's even harder to speculate about what happens to water that is contaminated by biohazards from un-preserved, decaying bodies that are wrapped in white cloth and placed on a bed of gravel directly on the ground in a bottomless four sided vault. Can we know with certainty that the volatile organic compounds that leach from the decaying bodies into ground will be adequately filtered by the soil?

After a permit is issued, and the final building and safety inspection is done, will there be testing and reports about the water that collects in the unseen underground water veins and larger arteries that feed into underground water wells and springs?

And, just how might water be contaminated if filtration is thought to happen as water soaks through soil? Because I do live here, I do see the bore holes in the ground that are made by small creatures. And I do see huge amounts of unfiltered water flow into these holes when it rains. These holes raise a separate concern about whether enough filtration takes place in the ground relative to how deep these bore hole go when the fast flowing waters create a whirlpool effect, and water erosion create deeper and deeper holes that collect more and more surface water as the unfiltered water travels deeper and deeper. This is just one way contaminated water might wind up in a well, without being filtered by the soil.

I cannot speculate about how neighboring domestic water wells are impacted, because like many older wells, some of the wells in this area predate the modern well reporting practices, and cannot be identified on water well maps, and their proximity to the graves cannot be determined.

What I do know with certainty, is that the setback is minimal in the area where graves meets the eastern boundary of APN 349-180-026, making the well on this residential parcel the closest well to the burial sites. While on the topic of rain soaked hills, we must consider the fact that after the county building and safety inspector has done the final inspection, graves will be continually dug without further inspections by the county planning agency to ensure compliance with regard to minimally graded areas and grave placement near hillsides, where sliding may occur in heavy rains…even when there is undisturbed ground. Over time unsupervised grading can open the possibility of expansion approval for additional graves in areas that were formally off limits due to former sloped conditions.

Burial site-to-domestic water well contamination can be compared to septic field contamination because both are concerned with leaching contaminants. The Riverside County distance requirement for septic field is 100 ft. from a domestic water well, and the World Health Organization (WHO) standard is about 50ft. from septic field to well.

While there is typically one active septic field on a residential lot, there will be an average of 813 of the 20,000 densely packed (separated by 6 inches of dirt) graves on each of the 24 or so acres that will be dedicated to graves at the proposed cemetery.

The WHO standard for a burial site distance to a domestic well is (250 meters) which is **820 feet**, with considerations for soil type and other conditions including emergencies like illness outbreak. The proposed cemetery project estimates 10 to 15 monthly burials. Without addressing concerns for traffic in this low traffic residential area, it should be noted that number of burials will likely increase over time. And in the event of an epidemic outbreak, the number of monthly burials will increase substantially.

Although there is no desire for pandemics, we must plan for them, while hoping they never happen. In the septic -versus- burial comparison, consider that there is typically one active septic system for domestic use on a one acre Rural Residential-VLDR lot. Then consider that there would be roughly 813 densely packed graves on a one acre Rural Residential-VLDR lot. Next, consider how the volatile biohazards at the cemetery would multiply exponentially with an outbreak, while the one domestic septic would remain at just one septic system in an outbreak. This septic to gravesite comparison makes is evident that 100 feet distance between hundreds of decomposing bodies and a domestic water well is just not inadequate.

Controlling the spread of infectious diseases and water quality is a priority that is acknowledged by the World Health Organization and the exponential increase of viruses, bacteria and other volatile organic compounds during disease outbreaks is a cited consideration for the 820 ft. distance between buried sites and domestic water wells. This is meaningful and should not be overlooked at the federal, state or county level, because it is a worldwide concern and lives are at stake.

There are consequences for knowingly allowing contaminant in the water. And some may not be aware of to the best standards for their community, After become informed, there is a definite legal obligation to ensure that communities have safe drinking water.

Request for Mitigation:

I therefore humbly request compassion and basic human kindness in considering a setback and open space between water wells and grave sites that is equal or similar to the more than 550 ft. open space distance between the proposed cemetery caretaker's residence and burial sites. This distance is not as stringent as the World Health Organization (WHO) grave-to-well standard, but it is better than the standard for a single domestic septic-to-well. And even though the proposed caretaker's residence will not be using a well the requested distance is closer to the WHO standards and would not be more favorable than the distance is for the cemetery caretaker's home. This distance would reduce burial site proximity issues for the proposed cemetery and better address:

- The emotional and psychological health and wellbeing of **both** mourners and existing residents. Some may choose to live within a minimal property line setback at an **existing** cemetery…having full foreknowledge and accept that a wall is sufficient or that the view from a small obscure window is insignificant. In this case the cemetery does not exist before/precede the residents. And we do not accept the view of grave digging, burial activities and uncovered graves while eating or from four large windows and a balcony that overlooks to proposed cemetery.

- Standards more in line with The World Health Organization (WHO) standards for proximity between domestic water wells and burial sites, particularly during cases of disease outbreaks and any yet to be discovered disease. This standard is a valid standard. Especially since disease outbreaks are unpredictable (for instance, a new case of the same plague that caused the Black Death was reported just last month (Aug 2025) in California).

Conclusion:
There are instances where subtle yet significant issues are not easily seen or addressed by the usual building, planning permitting process. In these cases, the conditional use permitting processes allows for the opportunity to unravel difficult truths and look more closely at issues that affect the health, safety and wellbeing of the community. This includes but is not limited to physical, emotional, and socio-economical health and wellbeing. When deeper issues like water quality and subtleties in the quality of life are revealed, the merit of these issued should be validated by the decision makers.

Please know that as veterans, we both served in the forces that guard our country and protect our way of life for over 28 years combined. Therefore, we have no desire to stop anyone from pursuing their way of life, nor is there a wish to prevent anyone from burying their dead in the manner they choose. In fact, apart for these prominent issues, there are many positive aspects of the proposed cemetery that we happily embrace.

While we join our neighbors who have concerns about the rate of decay with natural burials where the body is placed on a bed of gravel, We would be equally concerned with the embalm-sealed caskets method that slows the release of biological and medical waste, because the formaldehyde and composite casket materials add other volatile compounds to ground and ultimately the water.

We thank you for your thoughtful consideration to this matter.

Respectfully Submitted

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